SREENIDHI MODEL UNITED NATIONS

SMUN 2026 | COMMITTEE BACKGROUND GUIDE

UNITED NATIONS GENERAL ASSEMBLY | FIRST COMMITTEE

DISEC

Disarmament and International Security Committee

COMMITTEE AGENDA

Preventing the Weaponization of Outer Space, with Special Emphasis on Strengthening International Cooperation and Establishing Mechanisms for the Peaceful Use of Outer Space

Diplomacy • Disarmament • International Cooperation

Message from the Secretariat

Dear Delegates,

Welcome to Sreenidhi Model United Nations 2026. The Secretariat is pleased to welcome you to the Disarmament and International Security Committee, where you will examine one of the most consequential questions confronting international security: how to preserve outer space as an environment of peaceful cooperation amid advancing technologies and growing strategic competition.

The purpose of this Background Guide is to provide an informed starting point for your preparation. It introduces the Committee's mandate, explains the agenda and its legal and diplomatic context, identifies major areas of disagreement, and offers questions that should inform substantive debate. It is not intended to prescribe a particular national position or substitute for independent research.

We encourage every delegate to understand the foreign policy of the Member State they represent, engage with opposing perspectives in good faith, and approach negotiations with both principle and pragmatism. Strong diplomacy requires more than identifying problems; it requires proposals that are precise, implementable and capable of attracting meaningful international cooperation.

We look forward to rigorous debate, thoughtful negotiation and resolutions that reflect the responsibilities entrusted to the First Committee.

Warm regards,
The Secretariat
Sreenidhi Model United Nations 2026

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A structured guide to informed research, principled diplomacy and practical committee deliberation.

01 Introduction to the Committee

The Disarmament and International Security Committee (DISEC), commonly referred to as the First Committee of the United Nations General Assembly, considers disarmament and international security matters within the scope of the United Nations Charter. It provides a universal deliberative forum in which Member States can identify threats, articulate national positions, debate the development of international norms and recommend collective responses. Its agenda includes nuclear and conventional disarmament, arms control, regional security, emerging military technologies and the prevention of an arms race in outer space.

DISEC is principally a deliberative and recommendatory body. It is not a global law-enforcement authority, does not itself conclude treaties on behalf of States and cannot independently impose binding sanctions. Its practical importance lies in building diplomatic consensus, shaping General Assembly resolutions, encouraging transparency and confidence-building, and referring questions to bodies and negotiating processes equipped to pursue further action.

The Committee's work intersects with that of the Conference on Disarmament, the United Nations Disarmament Commission and the United Nations Office for Disarmament Affairs. On questions concerning the peaceful uses and legal governance of space, delegates should also understand the distinct mandate of the Committee on the Peaceful Uses of Outer Space (COPUOS) and the role of the United Nations Office for Outer Space Affairs (UNOOSA). Their functions are complementary rather than interchangeable: DISEC primarily approaches outer space from an international security and disarmament perspective.

For this agenda, DISEC is particularly significant because space technologies are increasingly integral to national security while also supporting everyday civilian life. Unilateral measures cannot adequately address threats that cross national boundaries, and diplomatic disagreement over acceptable military conduct in space can affect the security of every space user. Delegates are therefore expected to speak from the perspective of their assigned countries, consider existing legal obligations and diplomatic positions, and propose measures that fall within the Committee's institutional competence.

"In a conflict, one party can always claim victory, but building peace must involve everybody."
— Martti Ahtisaari, Nobel Peace Prize Lecture (2008)

02 Introduction to the Agenda

Outer space is no longer exclusively the domain of scientific exploration. Satellites enable telecommunications, financial transactions, navigation, disaster response, environmental monitoring, agricultural planning and research. The same infrastructure can support military communications, surveillance, missile-warning systems and strategic operations. As access to space expands among governments and commercial operators, its value—and its vulnerability—continues to increase.

The agenda asks how the international community can prevent the weaponization of outer space while preserving legitimate, peaceful and sustainable space activities. This is not simply a question of whether satellites may have military functions. It concerns the development, deployment, testing or use of capabilities intended to damage, disable, disrupt or threaten space systems; the incentives for states to acquire such capabilities; and the possibility that military competition could spread into an environment on which countries collectively depend.

The challenge is partly legal and partly political. Foundational space treaties constrain certain activities, but they do not provide a comprehensive prohibition on all conventional space weapons or all forms of hostile interference. New technologies are frequently dual-use, meaning that a capability intended for civilian or protective functions may also be adapted for military purposes. Consequently, transparency, verification, responsible behaviour, strategic stability and international cooperation are central to any meaningful solution.

The debate should avoid two simplistic assumptions: that every military use of a satellite is necessarily prohibited, and that anything not expressly prohibited is therefore strategically harmless. Delegates must distinguish law from policy, existing obligations from proposed norms, and theoretical threats from documented conduct.

03 Explanation of the Agenda

3.1 Historical Context: From Peaceful Exploration to Strategic Competition

The earliest decades of the space age linked scientific achievement with strategic rivalry. Following the launch of Sputnik in 1957, space capabilities developed alongside the Cold War competition in ballistic missiles, reconnaissance and communications. These developments prompted efforts to articulate legal principles governing activities beyond national territory. The 1963 General Assembly Declaration of Legal Principles and the 1967 Outer Space Treaty established an enduring foundation for cooperation, state responsibility and important limits on military activity in outer space.

The evolution of space security since the end of the Cold War has been shaped by wider satellite dependence, the entry of additional spacefaring states and the rapid growth of commercial operators. Debates on the Prevention of an Arms Race in Outer Space have persisted in multilateral disarmament forums, while the technological distinction between a satellite that serves legitimate civilian or defence functions and a capability that can be used to disable another satellite has become increasingly difficult to draw.

3.2 Understanding militarization, weaponization and counterspace capabilities

Militarization generally refers to the use of space-based assets in support of military activities, such as observation, navigation or communications. Weaponization is a narrower and contested concept, generally concerned with placing or employing weapons or hostile capabilities in, from or against outer space. Counterspace capabilities may be ground-based, space-based or cyber/electromagnetic; examples include missiles designed to destroy satellites, systems intended to interfere with satellite communications, cyber operations against supporting networks and technologies capable of approaching or manipulating another space object. Definitions matter because overly broad formulations may inadvertently capture ordinary civilian operations or legitimate military support functions.

3.3 Why an arms race in outer space is a collective security concern

A state may pursue defensive space capabilities because it fears that adversaries could disable its satellites. Other states may interpret the same investment as an offensive threat and respond by developing comparable systems. This action–reaction dynamic can produce an arms race even where governments profess peaceful intentions. The destruction or disruption of a satellite can also impair services used by third states, commercial operators and humanitarian responders. Escalation risks are especially serious when national leaders cannot readily determine whether an incident resulted from deliberate attack, technical malfunction, environmental conditions or an accident.

3.4 Anti-satellite weapons, interference and orbital debris

Anti-satellite (ASAT) capabilities attract particular concern because the loss of a satellite may affect both civilian and defence networks. Destructive kinetic tests can generate orbital debris, which may remain hazardous long after the original event and can threaten unrelated spacecraft. Non-kinetic means—including radio-frequency interference, spoofing, dazzling or cyber intrusions—may be less visible and more difficult to attribute, yet still cause significant harm. Delegates should distinguish between the different technologies rather than assume that identical verification or prohibition mechanisms will apply to all of them. A key policy issue is whether specific hazardous conduct, such as debris-generating destructive testing, should be addressed through narrower commitments even before agreement on a comprehensive treaty is reached.

3.5 Current Challenges: Security, Attribution and Shared Vulnerability

Contemporary challenges extend beyond the placement of physical weapons in orbit. Ground-based anti-satellite systems, electronic jamming, cyber intrusion, directed-energy capabilities and operations conducted in close proximity to satellites may threaten the availability or integrity of space-based services. Many of these technologies are dual-use, making intention difficult to establish and complicating proposals that would prohibit particular equipment rather than clearly defined conduct.

The danger is not confined to an affected satellite. Disruption can cascade into civilian communications, navigation, emergency response and financial systems, while debris created by destructive engagements may remain hazardous to unrelated spacecraft. Strategic mistrust, incomplete information about national capabilities, divergent views about verification and uneven access to space technology further complicate negotiation. The growing role of private operators also raises questions about licensing, supervision, accountability and cooperation between public authorities and industry.

3.6 Existing international law: what it prohibits—and what it does not

The 1967 Outer Space Treaty is the foundational instrument. Article I establishes principles of access and use for the benefit and in the interests of all countries; Article II prohibits national appropriation of outer space; and Article III requires space activities to be conducted in accordance with international law, including the United Nations Charter. Under Article IV, States Parties must not place nuclear weapons or other weapons of mass destruction in orbit, install them on celestial bodies or station them in outer space in another manner. The Moon and other celestial bodies are reserved exclusively for peaceful purposes, with express restrictions on military bases, weapons testing and military manoeuvres there. These restrictions must not be inaccurately described as a general treaty prohibition on every conventional weapon in Earth orbit.

Other provisions remain important: Article VI concerns international responsibility for national activities, including those conducted by non-governmental entities; Article VII addresses liability in specified circumstances; and Article IX concerns due regard and potentially harmful interference,

including consultation obligations in relevant situations. The 1972 Liability Convention and 1975 Registration Convention supplement the legal architecture. General rules under the United Nations Charter, and where applicable international humanitarian law, may also be relevant to hostile operations. A treaty's applicability, scope and enforceability should be analysed carefully rather than presumed.

3.7 Institutional architecture and contemporary diplomatic approaches

Diplomatic discussions have long addressed the Prevention of an Arms Race in Outer Space (PAROS). Proposals have varied in their emphasis: some states advocate a binding instrument restricting the placement of weapons in space and the threat or use of force against space objects, while others emphasise practical norms of responsible behaviour, risk-reduction measures and improved transparency as nearer-term steps. These approaches need not be mutually exclusive, but delegates should assess differences in definitions, verification, confidence, state practice and political feasibility. DISEC may recommend cooperative measures or endorse further negotiations; COPUOS primarily addresses the peaceful uses and long-term sustainability of outer space, whereas specialist disarmament processes focus on security and arms-control questions.

3.8 Current International Response and Emerging Areas of Cooperation

The international response has developed along complementary diplomatic and legal tracks. Within the United Nations, discussion of the Prevention of an Arms Race in Outer Space continues alongside consideration of responsible state behaviour, transparency and confidence-building measures, and proposals for additional international commitments. States differ on the relative merits of legally binding prohibitions and voluntary norms, particularly where definitions, attribution and verification remain contested.

The General Assembly and its First Committee provide forums for building political consensus and articulating recommendations, while the Conference on Disarmament is a forum for multilateral disarmament negotiation. The United Nations Committee on the Peaceful Uses of Outer Space addresses civilian cooperation, space law and sustainability, including measures intended to reduce long-term orbital risks. These bodies have distinct mandates; proposals should therefore identify the appropriate institution and distinguish diplomatic commitments from measures requiring negotiation, domestic implementation or technical verification.

Potential areas for practical cooperation include advance notification of hazardous activities, improved information exchange concerning space objects, emergency communication channels, consultations following potentially threatening encounters, and measures discouraging debris-generating anti-satellite tests. Delegates should assess how each proposal could be implemented, monitored and made accessible to states with different technological capacities.

3.9 Transparency, verification and accountability

Norms without credible implementation risk becoming aspirational. Possible tools include pre-launch notifications, exchanges of information on national space policies, contact points for urgent communications, notifications of potentially hazardous manoeuvres, voluntary commitments against particular destructive tests, data-sharing concerning space situational awareness, and processes for clarifying incidents. More ambitious agreements may require verification standards, reporting obligations, independent technical analysis and graduated procedures for addressing non-compliance. Each proposal must confront practical barriers: classified military information, dual-use technologies, differing technical capabilities and the risk that data disclosed in the name of transparency could itself create security vulnerabilities.

3.10 Equity, commercial participation and long-term sustainability

The benefits of space activity extend far beyond the comparatively small number of major launch-capable states. Developing countries rely on satellite-enabled services and have an interest in equitable access, technical cooperation and protection against disruptions they did not cause. Commercial operators now own or manage a substantial share of some space infrastructure, making domestic licensing, supervision and public–private coordination important. The economic and environmental implications are similarly connected: collisions, debris and conflict may raise operating costs, narrow access to useful orbits and jeopardise scientific missions for future generations. Delegates should therefore connect space security with responsible conduct, capacity-building and international cooperation without allowing the sustainability discussion to displace the Committee's security mandate.

"Peace is more precious than diamonds or silver or gold." — Martin Luther King Jr., Nobel Peace Prize Lecture (1964)

3.11 From diagnosis to workable committee proposals

A strong resolution must move beyond expressing concern. Delegates should specify the conduct to be encouraged or discouraged, the institutional forum responsible, whether a measure is voluntary or legally binding, the actors covered, relevant verification or reporting arrangements, and the resources needed for implementation. Measures should be calibrated to the range of national capabilities and security concerns. The ultimate test is whether a proposal could reduce mistrust or dangerous behaviour without foreclosing lawful scientific, civilian and commercial space activities.

04 Reference Links and Resources

The following references are drawn from the original DISEC guide. Select a title to open the resource. Delegates should independently verify the currency and relevance of individual publications.

01. **United Nations Office for Disarmament Affairs (UNODA)**

Arms control, prevention of an arms race in outer space and multilateral disarmament processes.

02. **United Nations Office for Outer Space Affairs (UNOOSA)**

Space law, international cooperation, registration of space objects and peaceful space activities.

03. **UN General Assembly First Committee (DISEC)**

Official First Committee documents, statements and General Assembly activity.

04. **United Nations: International Space Law**

Introductory material on international space law and the governing legal framework.

05. **Reuters**

Reporting on developments in space security, satellite technology and international negotiations.

06. **Stockholm International Peace Research Institute (SIPRI)**

Independent research on international security, arms control and emerging military technologies.

07. **Secure World Foundation**

Research on responsible behaviour, counterspace capabilities and space sustainability.

08. **United Nations Committee on the Peaceful Uses of Outer Space (COPUOS)**

Work on the peaceful use and long-term sustainability of outer space.

09. **United Nations Treaty Collection**

Primary texts and verified treaty participation records.

10. **UN General Assembly Resolution A/RES/80/19 (2025)**

The General Assembly's consideration of preventing an arms race in outer space.

05 Questions to Consider

The following questions are intended to guide research, country-position papers, moderated caucuses and draft resolutions. Delegates should support their positions with treaty provisions, official state statements, voting records and reliable technical evidence.

01. How should the committee distinguish the militarization of outer space from its weaponization, and which activities should fall within any proposed restrictions?

02. Which obligations under the Outer Space Treaty and related instruments currently regulate military or potentially hostile space activities, and where do substantive or enforcement gaps remain?

03. How does the assigned country define its national security interests in outer space, and how are those interests reflected in its official policies and diplomatic record?

04. What are the principal risks posed by kinetic anti-satellite tests, non-kinetic interference and cyber operations against space infrastructure?

05. Should Member States prioritise a binding arms-control instrument, voluntary norms of responsible behaviour, or a phased combination of both? What would make the preferred approach credible?

06. What forms of notification, information-sharing, consultation and crisis communication could reduce miscalculation without disclosing sensitive national security information?

07. How could compliance be assessed when relevant technologies are dual-use and harmful interference may be difficult to attribute?

08. What realistic responsibilities should states assume for national private operators, and what measures could protect essential civilian and humanitarian satellite services?

09. How should the interests of developing and non-spacefaring states be represented in negotiations and technical cooperation arrangements?

10. What distinct contributions can DISEC, the Conference on Disarmament, COPUOS, UNOOSA and other relevant institutions make, within their respective mandates?

11. How can proposed measures address debris-generating conduct and preserve the long-term sustainability of the orbital environment?

12. What funding, technical assistance, reporting, review and dispute-resolution mechanisms would be required to make a proposed initiative operational?

13. Which positions are likely to command broad international support, and what compromises would be necessary to reconcile competing security concerns?